India’s journey in the SCO would depend mostly on how India and China weigh ties on security and economic calculations. China is laying great emphasis on building a regional framework, and India features high in it. India should utilise this momentum to mitigate some of its core concerns as well as limiting China’s rising regional outreach while pursuing a nuanced diplomatic approach.

India–China bilateral ties are certainly back on track after the Doklam standoff in 2017. The Wuhan Summit in April 2018 between Xi and Modi provided a reset in relations, and they agreed to “handle all differences through peaceful means.” The challenge is to translate the confidence built there into a predictable, if not durable, atmosphere of peace along the Himalayan borderland. Both leaders have issued “strategic guidance” to their respective militaries to lower tensions on the frontier. No doubt Xi and Modi deserve credit for the success of the Wuhan summit, and it created positive momentum ahead of the SCO’s Qingdao Summit a few weeks later, on 9–10 June, in which India for the first time attended as a full member of the SCO.

Clearly, after the Wuhan Summit and India’s entry into the SCO, both sides seem to be working on a clear roadmap to narrow the huge trade imbalance. To bridge the financial impact of the deficit, China has committed to make more investments in India and has also agreed to open up greater market access to Indian products.[45] This intention was further reiterated at the 2019 Chennai summit between Modi and Xi, with the two leaders announcing the creation of a “High-Level Economic and Trade Dialogue” mechanism.[46]

The Wuhan and Qingdao Summits in 2018, as well as the 2019 Chennai Summit, took place in the midst of extraordinary global disapproval of the belligerence, sanctions, and protectionist measures of the United States under the Trump administration, which threaten to cast a